

In the Matter of)
)
 Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's) RM-____
 Rules to Authorize Expanded Special Event)
 Amateur Radio Call Sign Formats)
)

To: The Secretary, Federal Communications Commission
Via: Office of the Secretary / ECFS
Attn: Chief, Wireless Telecommunications Bureau, Mobility Division

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I. INTRODUCTION AND SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

1. For eighty years, the amateur radio service has served as a proving ground for radio operators, a resource for emergency communications, and a form of goodwill diplomacy between the United States and other nations. A central feature of that service — in the United States and abroad — is the "special event station": a temporary, thematically named call sign that amateur clubs and individuals use to commemorate anniversaries, expositions, disaster-relief operations, and other events of public significance.

2. Since 1997, the Commission's rules have permitted U.S. amateur licensees to use special event call signs, but *only* in the exceptionally narrow "1x1" format — a single letter (K, N, or W), a single digit, and a single letter (e.g., "W1A").¹ That 750-combination block was carved out in 1994-95 specifically because it was the *least* commercially useful and thus *least* costly format the Commission could set aside without depleting the sequential and vanity call sign systems used for permanent station licensing.²

3. In the three decades since, every comparable ITU member administration this Petitioner could identify with verifiable primary-source documentation — the United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, Germany, Ireland, and Japan — has adopted special event call sign systems that permit substantially longer, more flexible, and more thematically expressive suffixes than the United States' 1x1 format, while preserving the same administrative

¹ 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii).

² *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Amateur Service Rules*, Report and Order, PR Docket No. 93-305, 10 FCC Rcd 1039, ¶ 13 (1995).

safeguards (coordinator or agency issuance, defined time limits, and mandatory identification with the licensee's assigned call sign).³ The International Telecommunication Union's own Radio Regulations expressly anticipate and authorize this practice: Article 19, No. 19.68A, added at the 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference, provides that "[o]n special occasions, for temporary use, administrations may authorize use of call signs with more than the four characters" otherwise specified for amateur stations.⁴

4. The United States is consequently an outlier. This Petition asks the Commission to exercise the discretion Congress and the ITU Radio Regulations already afford it, and to amend Part 97 to authorize a second, longer special event call sign format — administered through the same certified coordinator system that has managed the 1x1 block without incident since 1997 — bringing U.S. practice into alignment with the rest of the world.

II. STATEMENT OF INTEREST OF PETITIONER

5. Petitioner is a federally licensed amateur radio operator whose interests, and those of the broader amateur radio community, are directly and adversely affected by the current rule. The scarcity and rigidity of the 1x1 format frequently prevents clubs and event organizers from obtaining a call sign that meaningfully identifies the event being commemorated (for example, a numeral marking a specific anniversary, as is now common practice abroad), forcing organizers either to accept an arbitrary, non-descriptive 1x1 combination or to forgo a special event call sign altogether. Petitioner has a direct interest in the Commission adopting a rule that permits more expressive, internationally consistent special event call signs.

³ See Section V, *infra*, and sources cited therein.

⁴ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, No. 19.68A (added World Radiocommunication Conference 2003).

III. BACKGROUND: THE CURRENT REGULATORY FRAMEWORK

A. The Amateur Service Call Sign System Generally

6. The Commission's amateur radio call sign systems are set out in 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3 and 97.19, and are administered under the Commission's general licensing authority in the Communications Act of 1934, as amended, 47 U.S.C. §§ 151-155, 301-609.⁵⁵ Amateur stations are ordinarily assigned "sequential" call signs by the Universal Licensing System, or may apply for a "vanity" call sign under 47 C.F.R. § 97.19, corresponding to formats (informally referred to by the Commission's licensing staff as Groups A through D) tied to the applicant's license class.⁶⁶

B. Origin and Scope of the 1x1 Special Event Call Sign System

7. Separate from the vanity system, 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii) defines a "special event call sign system" under which a station licensee may substitute, for the period of a "self-determined special event," a call sign selected from a common database "coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the amateur station special event call sign data base coordinators." The rule fixes the format precisely: "a single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by a single numeral 0 through 9, followed by a single letter A through W or Y or Z (for example K1A)."⁷⁷ Section 97.119(d) permits a station to identify using this substitute call sign, provided the station also transmits its regularly assigned call sign at least once per hour.⁸⁸

8. This system originates in two Commission orders. First, in a Report and Order in PR Docket No. 93-305, the Commission reserved the block of "750 one-by-one call signs" — the

⁵⁵ 47 U.S.C. §§ 151-155, 301-609; see also authority citation to 47 C.F.R. Part 97, 48 Stat. 1066, 1082, as amended; 47 U.S.C. §§ 154, 303.

⁶⁶ 47 C.F.R. § 97.19. The "Group A/B/C/D" terminology is used in the Commission's public licensing guidance (e.g., FCC, *Amateur Call Sign Systems*, wireless.fcc.gov) rather than in the text of § 97.19 itself.

⁷⁷ 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii).

rarest and least commercially valuable call sign format under the U.S. system — for temporary use during events of special significance to the amateur community.⁹ Second, in *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Concerning Amateur Radio Service*, FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57 (adopted March 20, 1997; released April 1, 1997), the Commission codified that reservation into the current rule text and delegated administration of the special event call sign database to Commission-certified volunteer "coordinators" under 47 C.F.R. § 0.131(p).

¹⁰¹⁰ The Commission's stated rationale for confining the format to the 1x1 block was one of scarcity: "we do not have additional call signs to assign for this purpose given that any such call signs would have to be taken from the sequential and vanity call sign systems, thus denying them to amateur operators who want them assigned to their primary and club stations."¹¹¹¹

9. That rationale — a zero-sum competition between special event call signs and the finite pool of sequential/vanity formats — does not describe the rule change proposed here. As explained in Section VI, *infra*, the format this Petition proposes would be created and administered in the same manner as the existing 1x1 block: a wholly new, non-permanent, coordinator-issued category that does not draw down the sequential or vanity call sign pools at all.

C. The Commission Has Already Been Asked to Do This — and Never Ruled on the Request

10. This is not the first time the idea proposed here has been placed before the Commission. In comments filed March 26, 2010, in WT Docket No. 09-209 — a proceeding

⁸ 47 C.F.R. § 97.119(d).

⁹ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Amateur Service Rules*, Report and Order, PR Docket No. 93-305, 10 FCC Rcd 1039, ¶ 13 (1995).

¹⁰ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Concerning Amateur Radio Service*, Report and Order, FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57, ¶¶ 12-16 (adopted Mar. 20, 1997; released Apr. 1, 1997) (consolidating RM-8301, RM-8418, and RM-8462); 47 C.F.R. § 0.131(p).

¹¹ FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57, ¶ 16.

concerning vanity and club station call sign rules generally — the American Radio Relay League ("ARRL"), the amateur service's principal national association, recommended that the Commission take up, "in a later, separate proceeding, but soon," an amendment to 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii) to expand the special event call sign format beyond the single 1x1 block. ARRL grounded that recommendation in the same 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference amendment to ITU Radio Regulations No. 19.68 discussed in Section IV, *infra*, and observed that "[i]t is time to reexamine this program to determine where deregulatory changes can be implemented to increase flexibility in the program."¹² The Commission's ensuing Report and Order in that docket, FCC 10-189 (released Nov. 8, 2010), addressed vanity call sign reassignment timing and club station license procedures, but did not address, adopt, or deny ARRL's special event call sign suggestion in any respect.¹³ The suggestion appears simply to have gone unaddressed in a docket devoted to other issues, rather than having been considered and rejected on the merits. This Petition formalizes, and requests a ruling on, that sixteen-year-old, previously unaddressed proposal.

11. A fresh Petition for Rulemaking is the only procedural vehicle now available to obtain that ruling. WT Docket No. 09-209 closed when the Commission released FCC 10-189, and ARRL's suggestion — offered as a passing recommendation for future action within comments filed on an unrelated NPRM — was never itself the subject of a request pending in that docket for the Commission to grant or deny. Nor is reconsideration of FCC 10-189 available: a petition for reconsideration must be filed "within thirty days from the date of public notice of such action," 47 C.F.R. § 1.106(f), a deadline that expired in December 2010.

¹² ARRL, Comments, WT Docket No. 09-209 (filed Mar. 26, 2010), *summarized in* ARRL, *ARRL Responds to FCC's NPRM Calling for New Rules on Vanity and Club Call Signs* (Apr. 7, 2010). Petitioner has relied on ARRL's own published summary of its filed comments; the underlying ECFS filing should be independently confirmed before this Petition is filed.

¹³ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Governing the Amateur Radio Services*, Report and Order, FCC 10-189, WT Docket No. 09-209, 25 FCC Rcd 16351 (released Nov. 8, 2010); *see* ARRL, *FCC Issues Report and Order on Vanity and Club Station Call Signs* (Nov. 10, 2010) (no mention of special event call signs in the Report and Order).

With both the original docket closed and the reconsideration window closed for a decade and a half, the only avenue by which the Commission can now be asked to act on this proposal is a new petition under 47 C.F.R. § 1.401 — precisely the vehicle Petitioner invokes here.

12. Petitioner further notes, for the sake of completeness and candor, that a Memorandum Opinion and Order on reconsideration in the original special event call sign docket, FCC 99-84, 14 FCC Rcd 8812 (1999) (WT Docket No. 95-57), is reported to have denied a petition for reconsideration seeking unspecified "changes . . . in the special event call sign system." Petitioner has not been able to confirm the substance of that 1999 petition or the Commission's stated reasoning, and flags it here so that it can be located and, if relevant, distinguished or addressed before this Petition is filed.¹⁴¹⁴

D. The 2017 Alessi Petition Is Not Controlling

13. Separately, in 2017, an individual petitioner sought to make a new "1x1x1" format (a letter, two digits, and a letter) generally available to Amateur Extra Class licensees as an alternative *permanent, sequential/vanity* call sign format, citing a perceived shortage of desirable 1x2 and 2x1 combinations. The Bureau dismissed that petition by letter, citing the roughly 15 million sequential call signs already available and an unspecified, similarly-reasoned petition rejected in 2010.¹⁵¹⁵ That petition addressed the *permanent* vanity call sign system and a claimed scarcity that the Bureau found factually unsupported — an entirely different rule section and rationale from the one at issue here. It did not address, and is not applicable to, the distinct question presented in this Petition: whether the *temporary*,

¹⁴ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Concerning Amateur Radio Service*, Memorandum Opinion and Order on Reconsideration, FCC 99-84, WT Docket No. 95-57, 14 FCC Rcd 8812 (1999). Petitioner has been unable to independently confirm the substance of the petition for reconsideration denied by this order or the Commission's stated reasoning, and identifies it here in the interest of candor with the Commission; it should be reviewed directly before this Petition is filed.

¹⁵ Letter from Scot Stone, Deputy Chief, Mobility Division, Wireless Telecommunications Bureau, FCC, to Thomas J. Alessi (Nov. 28, 2017), *reported in* ARRL, *FCC Dismisses Radio Amateur's Petition to Revise Call Sign Rules*, arrl.org/news (Dec. 2017).

coordinator-administered special event system — which by definition does not compete with the permanent call sign pool — should be permitted a second, longer format. Nor is the 2019 denial of a station-identification-timing petition unrelated to call sign format, RM-11826, applicable here; that petition sought an identification-timing exception for emergency nets under § 97.119(a), an unrelated subsection.¹⁶ Apart from the unresolved 1999 order noted in paragraph 12, above, Petitioner is not aware of any FCC order denying, on the merits, a request to expand the special event call sign format itself, and no reported judicial decision addresses amateur call sign format policy; the only governing authority is the agency's own orders discussed above.

IV. INTERNATIONAL LAW CONFIRMS THE COMMISSION'S DISCRETION TO ADOPT LONGER SPECIAL EVENT CALL SIGNS

14. The United States' amateur call signs are drawn from international call sign series allocated to it under Appendix 42 to the ITU Radio Regulations (the blocks AAA-ALZ, KAA-KZZ, NAA-NZZ, and WAA-WZZ).¹⁷ Article 19 of the Radio Regulations governs how those series may be used. Two provisions are directly relevant.

15. First, No. 19.38 provides that "[e]ach administration shall choose the call signs from the international series allocated or supplied to it," and expressly excludes call signs assigned to amateur stations from the notification requirements that apply to other services.¹⁸ The ITU accordingly leaves the assignment of amateur call signs — including special event call signs — entirely to the discretion of the national administration; the Commission need not seek any international clearance to adopt the rule proposed here.

16. Second, and most directly on point, No. 19.68 sets a baseline format for amateur call signs (a nationality prefix, a digit other than 0 or 1, and up to four further characters

¹⁶ *Robert Dukish*, Order, RM-11826 (Wireless Telecomm. Bur., Mobility Div.), *summarized in FCC, Robert Dukish Rulemaking Petition Decision*; ARRL news coverage of RM-11826 (2018-2019).

¹⁷ ITU Radio Regulations, Appendix 42, Table of Allocation of International Call Sign Series.

ending in a letter). No. 19.68A, added by the 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference, then creates the specific carve-out this Petition invokes: "On special occasions, for temporary use, administrations may authorize use of call signs with more than the four characters referred to in No. 19.68."¹⁹ The Radio Regulations — a binding international treaty to which the United States is a party — thus expressly contemplate and authorize exactly the kind of extended, temporary, special-occasion call sign this Petition requests. The Commission's current 1x1-only rule is more restrictive than international law requires; it is a matter of domestic policy choice, not treaty obligation.

V. COMPARATIVE PRACTICE: OTHER ADMINISTRATIONS ALREADY AUTHORIZE LONGER SPECIAL EVENT CALL SIGNS

17. Exercising the very discretion described above, a number of ITU member administrations comparable to the United States already authorize special event call signs substantially longer and more flexible than the U.S. 1x1 format. The table below summarizes verified practice in six jurisdictions:

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
United Kingdom	Ofcom	Issued directly by Ofcom (RSGB advisory only) ²⁰	"GB" (and related) prefixes with 2-3 letter suffixes; an extended "Special SES" format permits longer, numeral-bearing suffixes for major	Up to 28 days per Notice of Variation	No fee identified

¹⁸ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, No. 19.38.

¹⁹ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, Nos. 19.68, 19.68A.

²⁰ Ofcom, *Applying for Special Event Station Notice of Variations Online*; Radio Society of Great Britain (RSGB), *Applying for a Special Event Station*.

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
			anniversaries (e.g., "GB100XYZ") ²¹ ²¹		
Canada	Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada (ISED)	Issued directly by ISED's Amateur Radio Service Centre, in a four-category system (RIC-9) ²² ²²	Special prefixes (e.g., "CG" substituted for "VE") combined with single-letter or up to four-character alphanumeric suffixes reserved exclusively for special event use ²³ ²³	2 weeks to 60 days depending on category	CAD \$60.00 per occurrence ²⁴ ²⁴
Australia	Australian Communications and Media Authority (ACMA)	Issued directly by ACMA; "VI" prefix restricted to club applicants ²⁵ ²⁵	"VI" substituted for "VK," combined with a thematic suffix of more than four characters	Short-term licence tied to the event, renewable	Approximately AUD \$34 per assignment ²⁶ ²⁶
Germany	Bundesnetzagentur (BNetzA)	Issued directly by BNetzA on a defined application form ²⁷ ²⁷	Prefix (e.g., DA0/DK0/DL0/DR0) plus a 4-to-7-character suffix ("4-7-stelliges Sonderrufzeichen")	Up to one year, non-renewable	Nominal administrative fee under the general fee ordinance

²¹ RSGB, *Ofcom Implements Phases 2 and 3 of the Amateur Radio Licence Review* (Oct. 17, 2025).

²² Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, *Radiocommunication Information Circular RIC-9, Call Sign Policy and Special Event Prefixes*, Issue 2 (Oct. 2005).

²³ RIC-9, §§ 1.3.2, 2.2.

²⁴ RIC-9, § 3.0.

²⁵ Australian Communications and Media Authority (ACMA), *Amateur Radio Call Sign Policy* (Sept. 2024).

²⁶ Wireless Institute of Australia, *ACMA Fee Changes* (Sept. 3, 2024).

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
Ireland	Commission for Communications Regulation (ComReg)	Issued directly by ComReg ²⁸	ComReg's own licensing guidelines state that "distinctive call signs — which may not necessarily comply with the normal rules — may be issued by ComReg for special event stations"	Days to one week of use; licence valid up to 12 months	Not confirmed
Japan	Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications (MIC), with JARL support ²⁹	Licensed directly to the sponsoring organization by MIC	"8J" or "8N" prefixes with suffix formats ranging from 2x1 to 2x5 (e.g., "8J2JAPAN" for major national events)	Tied to event period	Standard station licensing fee schedule

18. Two features of this comparative practice are notable. First, every jurisdiction listed retains the same administrative safeguards the Commission already relies on domestically for the 1x1 system — issuance (directly or through a delegated coordinator) by the licensing authority, a fixed and limited period of validity, and a requirement that the temporary call sign be used only for the stated event. Second, none of these jurisdictions has reported that longer special event formats have caused interference, database confusion, or misidentification

²⁷ Bundesnetzagentur, *Antrag auf Zuteilung eines 4-7-stelligen Sonderrufzeichens*, Ref. 225 (Feb. 2025).

²⁸ Commission for Communications Regulation (ComReg), *Amateur Station Licence Guidelines*, ComReg Document 09/45R5 (2023).

²⁹ Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications (Japan); Japan Amateur Radio League (JARL), *Expo 2025 Special Station Information*.

problems; to the contrary, several (the United Kingdom's "Special SES" format and Japan's practice for milestone national events) were adopted specifically to allow the call sign itself to communicate the anniversary or event being commemorated — the very flexibility the current U.S. 1x1 format forecloses.

VI. THE PROPOSED RULE SERVES THE PUBLIC INTEREST AND ALIGNS UNITED STATES PRACTICE WITH THE REST OF THE WORLD

19. The Commission's 1997 order confined special event call signs to the 1x1 block because any longer or more available format would necessarily be "taken from the sequential and vanity call sign systems, thus denying them to amateur operators who want them assigned to their primary and club stations."¹¹ That scarcity concern does not apply here. This Petition does not ask the Commission to draw new special event call signs from the sequential or vanity pools. It asks the Commission to authorize a **second, separately defined, coordinator-administered special event format** — for example, a "1x2" or short alphanumeric-suffix format analogous to Canada's four-character special event suffixes or Germany's four-to-seven character suffixes — issued and tracked through the same certified special event call sign database coordinators that have administered the 1x1 system without reported difficulty for nearly thirty years, and subject to the same hourly self-identification safeguard already codified at 47 C.F.R. § 97.119(d).

20. Adopting such a rule would:

- a. Bring United States practice into direct alignment with the United Kingdom's practice
- b. Exercise, rather than fall short of, the flexibility the ITU Radio Regulations provide
- c. Allow U.S. amateur clubs and event organizers to select call signs that better reflect the event

d. Impose no cost on, and require no change to, the existing sequential and

VII. PROPOSED RULE TEXT

21. Petitioner proposes that the Commission amend 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3(a)(11) and 97.119(d) as follows (new text underlined; this is illustrative proposed text for the Commission's consideration and further refinement in a Notice of Proposed Rulemaking):

§ 97.3 Definitions.

(a) * * *

(11) * * *

(iii) *Special event call sign system.* A system used to select from a common data base a call sign for use by an amateur station in conjunction with an event of special significance. The call sign is selected by the station licensee from a list of call signs shown on a common data base coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the amateur station special event call sign data base coordinators. The call sign must have the single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by a single numeral 0 through 9, followed by a single letter A through W or Y or Z (for example K1A), or, at the option of the licensee, the single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by a single numeral 0 through 9, followed by two through five letters A through W, Y, or Z (for example K1ABC or K1ANNIV), subject to such limits on duration and availability as the Commission may by Public Notice prescribe. The special event call sign is substituted for the call sign shown on the station license grant while the station is transmitting. The FCC will issue public announcements detailing the procedures of the special event call sign system.

§ 97.119 Station identification.

(d) When transmitting in conjunction with an event of special significance, a station may substitute for its assigned call sign a special event call sign, in either format authorized under § 97.3(a)(11)(iii), as shown for that station for that period of time on the common data base coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the special event call sign data base coordinators. Additionally, the station must transmit its assigned call sign at least once per hour during such transmissions.

22. Petitioner defers to the Commission and its certified special event call sign coordinators on the precise suffix-length limits, database mechanics, and any transition period, and welcomes a Notice of Proposed Rulemaking inviting comment on these implementation details.

VIII. CONCLUSION

23. For the foregoing reasons, Petitioner respectfully requests that the Commission institute a rulemaking proceeding to amend 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3(a)(11)(iii) and 97.119(d) to authorize an additional, longer special event amateur radio call sign format, as set forth above, in order to bring United States practice into alignment with the ITU Radio Regulations and with the practice of comparable foreign administrations.

Respectfully submitted,

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[Date to be added prior to filing]